NATHAN SUNDAY

University of Michigan
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EDUCATION

University of Michigan
PhD. Candidate in Economics — 2027 (Expected)
Master of Arts in Economics — 2024

Makerere University
Master of Arts in Economics — 2019
Bachelor of Science with Education (Mathematics and Economics) — 2014

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Public Finance (Primary)

Development Economics (Secondary)

JOB MARKET PAPER

"Beyond Local Revenue: Commercial Property Taxes, Firm Behavior, and Fiscal Externalities"

- ***Abstract:*** *Property taxation is widely viewed as a promising source of revenue for developing countries, yet evidence on its economic effects remains limited. Using administrative data from corporate and employee tax returns in a staggered difference-in-differences design, I show that a reform that substantially increased commercial property tax liabilities in Kampala, Uganda significantly reduced firm survival but had no significant effects on revenues or profits among active firms. Firms adjusted labor costs through reductions in formal employment and wages, with wage informalization accounting for most of the decline in the formal wage bill. These adjustments had progressive distributional consequences within firms, with higher-earning workers bearing a disproportionate share of the wage declines. The rental cost channel plays an important role in transmitting the burden of property tax to tenant firms, with the reform increasing business rental expenses by 6.3 percent. Finally, I show that these firm-level responses generate a vertical fiscal externality: each UGX 1 increase in local property tax revenue reduces central government income tax revenue by approximately UGX 0.3. Incorporating this externality into a Marginal Value of Public Funds framework, I estimate that raising UGX 1 of net consolidated public revenue costs the public UGX 1.53, implying that the reform is welfare-improving only if the value of the public goods it finances exceeds this cost.*

WORKING PAPERS

"Beyond the Beneficiary: Old-Age Pensions and the Labor Market Outcomes of Younger Adults"

- ***Summary:*** *This paper examines whether non-contributory old-age pension programs have spillover effects on labor supply and earnings of ineligible working-age adults within the household.*
- Prior version was awarded the prize for **Outstanding Third Year Paper**, 2024, Department of Economics, University of Michigan

"The Economic Effects of Decentralization: Firm Performance and Fiscal Capacity", (with Laston Manja)

- ***Summary:*** *Using administrative tax data from Uganda, this paper examines whether decentralization of governance generates tangible gains for the private sector and how it affects the fiscal capacity of the central government.*

WORK IN PROGRESS

"Using Digital Connectivity to Expand Global Job Opportunities for African Workers", (with Dean Yang, David Mckenzie, Heesung Kim, Robertson Khataza, and Ted Lui). AEA RCT Registry. July 08, 2026. https://doi.org/10.1257/rct.16818-2.0

- ***Summary:*** *This projects examines whether reducing entry barriers into remote work, such as information and reputation frictions as well as liquidity constraints, improves remote-work outcomes for young African professionals.*

SELECTED PRE-DOCTORAL PUBLICATIONS

"Does Corruption Explain the Decision to Invest and the Value of Investment? Revisiting Evidence from Sub-Saharan African Firms" (with Ibrahim Mike Okumu and Edward Bbaale). *Journal of International Development*, 2025. Vol. 37: 1622–1639.

"Gender of a Manager and Firm Performance in Africa: Does the Business Environment Play a Moderating Role?" (with Ibrahim Mike Okumu and Edward Bbaale). *Journal of International Development*, 2024. Vol. 36: 3082–3124.

"How Specific Resilience Pillars Mitigate the Impact of Drought on Food Security: Evidence from Uganda" (with Rehema Kahunde, Blessing Atwine, Adesoji Adelaja, and Justin George). *Food Security*, 2023. Vol. 15: 111–131.

Book Chapters

"Employment and Productivity of Uganda's SMEs in the Face of COVID-19: A Gender Perspective" (with Brian Sserunjogi, Paul Lakuma, and Rehema Kahunde). In *Socioeconomic Shocks and Africa's Development Agenda*, Evans Osabuohien, Gbadebo Odularu, Daniel Ufua, and Romanus Osabohien (eds). Routledge, 2023.

SELECTED POLICY REPORTS AND ARTICLES

"A Rapid Assessment of the Effect of the COVID-19 Lockdown on Livelihoods and Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises in Uganda" (with Francis Mwesigye, Tony Odokonyero, and Mildred Barungi), *Economic Policy Research Centre*, Policy Note: 8, August 2021. Link to the Report

"Impact of COVID-19 on Micro, Small, and Medium Businesses in Uganda" (blog with Paul Lakuma), *Brookings, Focus in Africa*, May 2020. Link to the Article

"The Uganda Business Climate Index (BCI)," co-author of multiple quarterly and special issues, 2019–2021. *Economic Policy Research Centre (EPRC)*, Uganda. https://eprcug.org/publications/uganda-business-climate-index/

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

PhD Fellow, National Planning Authority, Uganda — May - Aug 2024

Research Analyst, Economic Policy Research Centre, Uganda — 2019 - 2021

Labor Support Officer, Research Unit, Ministry of Gender, Labor & Social Development, Uganda — 2018 - 2019

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Graduate Student Instructor, University of Michigan 2022-2026

- Intermediate Macroeconomics (ECON 402) Fall 2024, Winter 2025, Fall 2025, Fall 2026
- Principles of Economics II, Macroeconomics (ECON 102) Fall 2022, Winter 2023, Fall 2023, Winter 2024, Winter 2026

Advanced Level Mathematics and Economics Teacher, Mandela Secondary School, Uganda Sep 2013- May 2016

GRANTS, AWARDS, AND SCHOLARSHIPS

Graduate Research Award, Department of Economics, University of Michigan, $3,000. 2025

Doctoral Research Grant, Rackham Graduate School, University of Michigan, $3,000. 2025

Outstanding Third Year Paper Award, 2024, Department of Economics, University of Michigan
Paper: Old-Age Pension and Labor Market Outcomes of Younger Individuals: Evidence from Uganda.

Structural Transformation of Agriculture and Rural Spaces (STARS) Fellowship Program, Cornell University, International Food Policy Research Institute, and Michigan State University. 2020

Thematic Research Grant (US$ 11,000), African Economic Research Consortium. 2019 - 2020
Paper: "Gender of a manager and firm performance in Africa: Does the business environment play a moderating role".

Masters degree scholarship, African Economic Research Consortium (AERC). 2016 - 2018

Undergraduate scholarship, Government of Uganda. 2011 - 2014

CONFERENCE AND SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

2026: 119th Annual Conference on Taxation (Scheduled), Pittsburgh, PA

2026: The 8th World Bank/ODI Global/IFS Public Finance Conference, Washington DC

2026: Economic Development Seminar (Scheduled), University of Michigan

2026: Public Finance Seminar, University of Michigan

2025: Public Finance Lunch Seminar, University of Michigan

2025: Economic Development Workshop, University of Michigan

2024: The 6th World Bank/IFS/ODI Public Finance Conference, Washington DC

2019: African Economic Research Consortium (AERC) Bi-Annual Research Workshop, Nairobi, Kenya

SKILLS

Languages: English (Proficient)

Software: Stata (Advanced), R (Intermediate), LaTeX (Advanced), MatLab (Intermediate)

OTHERS

Citizenship: Citizen of Uganda (F-1 Visa)

DISSERTATION COMMITTEE MEMBERS

James Hines (Co-Chair)
Department of Economics
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